MYWALK
Kingdom Living Series

Proverbs 31:10–31

The Woman of Valour

אשת חייל — Eshet Chayil

“Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain;”
“but a woman who fears Yahweh, she shall be praised.”
— Proverbs 31:30 (WEB)

1. Audience & Context

Who Wrote It, and For Whom?

Proverbs 31 is the conclusion of the entire book of Proverbs, and it ends with two distinct poems. The first (vv. 1–9) is the instruction of King Lemuel's mother—a queen mother teaching her royal son about integrity and justice. The second (vv. 10–31) is the famous acrostic poem known in Jewish tradition as Eshet Chayil: "Woman of Valour."

The book of Proverbs is addressed primarily to young men ("my son" is the recurring address), yet it opens and closes with women as the authoritative voices. Wisdom herself is personified as a woman (Proverbs 8–9), and the book ends with a portrait of a woman who embodies her. This is a deliberate literary frame: the young man who began Proverbs learning to seek wisdom ends by recognising her in a real, embodied human life.

Authorship and Dating

The title of 31:1 attributes these words to King Lemuel's mother. While Lemuel cannot be identified with certainty—some Jewish commentators identified him with Solomon; others suggest he was a non-Israelite king—what is certain is that the poem's final form belongs to the later editing of Proverbs, likely during or after the return from exile (6th–5th century BC), when the book was compiled in its canonical shape.

Cultural Setting

The poem describes a woman of means in ancient Israelite society—likely urban, prosperous, married into a family of standing. This matters: she is not a servant or slave but a woman with genuine agency. She manages commercial transactions, employs household staff, and makes independent investment decisions. She is not defined solely by her domestic role, though she is deeply engaged in it. Dismissing her as "just a housewife" misreads the poem entirely.

Liturgical Life

In Jewish practice, Proverbs 31:10–31 is traditionally sung by husbands to their wives at the Shabbat table on Friday evenings—not as a measuring stick, but as a blessing and a song of praise. This liturgical context is crucial: the poem was designed to be sung over a woman, not recited at her as a standard. It is a celebration, not a curriculum.

2. Hebrew Literary Note — The Acrostic Structure

The poem is an acrostic: each of its 22 verses begins with a successive letter of the Hebrew alphabet, from aleph (א) to taw (ת). This literary device—used also in Psalm 119, Psalm 34, and the book of Lamentations—carries deliberate meaning.

In Hebrew literary culture, an acrostic from aleph to taw signified completeness, much as we say "from A to Z." The poem is not a partial list of virtues the woman happens to have. It is declaring, through its very structure, that she embodies virtue in its fullness. The acrostic also served as a memory device: the poem was designed to be memorised, sung, and carried.

For the reader today, the structural point is this: you are not reading a checklist. You are reading a poem about wholeness. The Woman of Valour is not someone

who has ticked 22 boxes; she is someone whose life, in its completeness, reflects the character of God.

3. The Word "Chayil" — A Note on Translation

The Hebrew phrase translated "worthy woman," "capable wife," "excellent wife," or "virtuous woman" in various English versions is אֵשֶׁת חַיִל (eshet chayil).

The word chayil (חַיִל) is powerful and frequently mistranslated. Across the Hebrew Bible, it most commonly means:

- Strength, might, valour — used of armies and warriors: "mighty men of valour" (Joshua 1:14; 6:2; 10:7)
- Wealth, resources, and substance
- Capability and competence in their fullest expression

The same word appears in Ruth 3:11 when Boaz says to Ruth: "All the city of my people knows that you are a woman of chayil." He is not calling her tidy or domestically competent. He is calling her a woman of strength and honour—the same honour attributed to warriors.

The Woman of Proverbs 31 is not primarily a homemaker. She is a warrior of character—strong, capable, strategic, generous, and rooted in the fear of the LORD. Every translation that softens chayil to "virtuous" or "capable" loses the heroic register of the original.

She is not the Ideal Wife. She is the Valiant Woman.

4. A Grace Note — Before You Read

This passage has been used, with the best of intentions, to wound women rather than celebrate them. It has been preached as a standard no one can reach—a portrait that leaves women feeling perpetually inadequate. If that is how you have heard it before, hear this first:

The poem does not begin with a command. It begins with a question: "Who can find a worthy woman?" The implication is not that she is impossibly rare—it is that she is astonishingly valuable. The poem is a song of praise, not a job description.

The woman in this poem is not anxious. She "laughs at the time to come" (v. 25). She is not performing for approval—she "fears the LORD" (v. 30), and her works flow from that centre. She is not trying to become the Woman of Proverbs 31; she is becoming her, one habit of grace at a time, rooted in a love for God that makes everything else possible.

Read this as a picture of who you are becoming in Christ, not a measuring rod for who you have failed to be.

5. The Story in Brief

The poem is not a narrative—it has no plot—but it has a movement. It begins with her value ("her price is far above rubies," v. 10) and the trust she has earned (vv. 11–12). It unfolds in a sweeping panorama of her daily life: her industry (vv. 13–19), her generosity (v. 20), her provision and care (vv. 21–22), her husband's honour (v. 23), her commerce (v. 24), her dignity and wisdom (vv. 25–26), her household oversight (v. 27), and finally her family's praise (vv. 28–29).

But the poem does not end with any of these things. It ends—in a deliberate anti-climax—with a theological statement: "Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain; but a woman who fears the LORD, she shall be praised" (v. 30). Everything in the poem flows from this. Her industry, generosity, wisdom, and commerce are not explained by her competence or personality. They are explained by her relationship with God. The fear of the LORD is the root; the rest of the poem is the fruit.

The final verse is a call to public honour: "Let her works praise her in the gates" (v. 31). In ancient Israel, the "gates" were the city's public forum—the place of commerce, law, and civic life. The poem ends by insisting that this woman's life deserves recognition in the fullest possible public sense.

6. The Central Point

The Woman of Valour is the embodied answer to the whole book of Proverbs.

Proverbs has spent thirty chapters calling its reader to seek Wisdom—to choose her, fear the LORD, walk in her ways, build a life on her foundation. Proverbs 31:10–31 shows us what it looks like when someone does exactly that.

The central point is not "be more productive" or "serve your family better." The central point is this:

A life ordered by the fear of the LORD becomes a life of extraordinary strength, generosity, wisdom, and dignity—and it will be praised.

The woman who fears the LORD does not become a better version of herself by trying harder. She becomes more fully herself as her fear of the LORD grows deeper. The poem is Wisdom's self-portrait.

7. The Question It Asks You

Which virtue in this woman's life comes most naturally to you—and which do you most avoid? What does your answer reveal about where fear of the LORD is, and is not, active in you?

8. Key Verses for Memorisation

Primary verse:

> *“Strength and dignity are her clothing. She laughs at the time to come.”*
> **— Proverbs 31:25 (WEB)**

For wisdom:

> *“She opens her mouth with wisdom. Kind instruction is on her tongue.”*
> **— Proverbs 31:26 (WEB)**

The climactic verse:

> *“Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain; but a woman who fears Yahweh, she shall be praised.”*
> **— Proverbs 31:30 (WEB)**

9. Scripture — Proverbs 31:10–31 (World English Bible)

PROVERBS 31:10–31

10 Who can find a worthy woman?
For her price is far above rubies.
11 The heart of her husband trusts in her.
He shall have no lack of gain.
12 She does him good, and not harm,
all the days of her life.
13 She seeks wool and flax,
and works with her hands willingly.
14 She is like the merchant ships.
She brings her bread from afar.
15 She rises also while it is yet night,
gives food to her household,
and portions to her servant girls.
16 She considers a field, and buys it.
With the fruit of her hands, she plants a vineyard.
17 She arms her loins with strength,
and makes her arms strong.
18 She perceives that her merchandise is profitable.
Her lamp doesn’t go out by night.
19 She lays her hands to the distaff,
and her hands hold the spindle.
20 She opens her arms to the poor;

yes, she extends her hands to the needy.
21 She is not afraid of the snow for her household,
for all her household are clothed in scarlet.
22 She makes for herself carpets of tapestry.
Her clothing is fine linen and purple.
23 Her husband is known in the gates,
when he sits among the elders of the land.
24 She makes linen garments and sells them,
and delivers sashes to the merchant.
25 Strength and dignity are her clothing.
She laughs at the time to come.
26 She opens her mouth with wisdom.
Kind instruction is on her tongue.
27 She looks well to the ways of her household,
and doesn't eat the bread of idleness.
28 Her children rise up and call her blessed.
Her husband also praises her:
29 "Many daughters have done virtuously,
but you excel them all."
30 Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain;
but a woman who fears Yahweh, she shall be praised.
31 Give her of the fruit of her hands!
Let her works praise her in the gates!

10. "Your Why" — Identity Aphorisms

Five identity-grounding statements drawn from the poem, for the MyWalk devotional layer. Speak these as declarations of who you are becoming, not goals you are striving toward.

- I am a woman of valour—not because of what I achieve, but because of whose I am.
- My strength and dignity come from the LORD, not from the approval of others.
- I extend my hands to the needy because I have received grace I did not earn.
- I open my mouth with wisdom because I have sat long at the feet of the Wise One.
- I laugh at the future because I trust the One who holds it.

11. Suggested Practices

Five concrete habits drawn from the poem, mapped to MyWalk habit categories:

- **Prayer & Worship:** Begin one day each week by praying Proverbs 31:30 over yourself—not as a goal but as a declaration: "I am a woman who fears the LORD." Let the prayer shape the day.

- **Generosity:** Identify one practical way each week to “extend your hands to the needy” (v. 20)—financial, practical, or relational. Let it be specific, not vague.
- **Wisdom:** Cultivate a monthly habit of reading one chapter of Proverbs in a single sitting, listening for wisdom’s voice rather than looking for rules.
- **Stewardship:** Choose one area of your home or work life that is languishing (the “bread of idleness”, v. 27) and give it one focused hour of intentional care this week.
- **Community:** Find one woman to speak “kind instruction” (v. 26) to this week—not flattery, but a true and specific word of encouragement grounded in what you have genuinely observed.

12. Women of Scripture — Living the Poem

The Eshet Chayil is not an abstract portrait. She has faces. The following women from Scripture each embody one or more of the poem's virtues with particular clarity. Read their stories alongside the poem, and the poem comes alive.

Ruth — The Woman the Poem Names

There is one woman in all of Scripture whom someone directly addresses as eshet chayil—using the exact phrase of Proverbs 31:10. That woman is Ruth.

In Ruth 3:11, Boaz says to her: "All the city of my people knows that you are a woman of chayil." This is not coincidence. Many scholars believe that the book of Ruth and the poem of Proverbs 31 are in deliberate conversation with each other—that Ruth is, in some sense, the poem's own illustration of itself.

What does Ruth embody? Everything. She works with her hands (gleaning in Boaz's fields from morning until evening). She rises early. She extends herself to the needy by remaining with Naomi when she had every right to leave. She makes wise, courageous commercial and social decisions—the threshing-floor scene in Ruth 3 is an act of extraordinary strategic courage. She wins the trust of the community, and her husband-to-be praises her publicly. Her fear of the God of Israel—the God she has adopted as her own—is the root of all of it.

Most significantly: her story ends at "the gates." Boaz conducts the legal transaction that secures Ruth's redemption at the city gate (Ruth 4:1–12)—the very location where Proverbs 31:31 insists the woman of valour should be praised. It is as if the poem is asking the reader: Remember Ruth? That is what I mean.

Key verses: Ruth 1:16–17; 2:11–12; 3:11; 4:13–17

Poem connections: vv. 10, 13, 15, 16, 20, 28, 31

Deborah — The Warrior Judge

Deborah (Judges 4–5) is the only woman in the Old Testament described as both a judge and a prophet—two of the highest offices in Israel. She held court under a palm tree between Ramah and Bethel, where the Israelites came to have their disputes decided (Judges 4:5). She was Israel's supreme court and its national conscience simultaneously.

When God called her to lead the military campaign against Sisera, she did not hesitate. She told Barak what the LORD had commanded, and when he refused to go without her, she went. But she also prophesied that the honour of the victory would go to a woman (Judges 4:9). That woman turned out to be Jael.

Deborah's song in Judges 5—one of the oldest pieces of poetry in the Hebrew Bible—is a masterwork of theological and military narrative. She "arose as a mother in Israel" (Judges 5:7), using the language of nurture and household even in the context of war. She is not domesticated strength; she is full-spectrum valour. She opens her mouth with wisdom (v. 26) before any audience Israel could offer.

Key verses: Judges 4:4–9; 5:1–7; 5:31

Poem connections: vv. 17, 25, 26, 27

Jael — Courageous Action at the Right Moment

Jael (Judges 4:17–22) is often overlooked, partly because her act of killing Sisera is jarring to modern readers. But within the poem's framework she is essential. Deborah had prophesied that "the LORD will sell Sisera into the hand of a woman" (Judges 4:9). Jael was that woman.

When Sisera fled the battlefield and sought shelter in her tent, she made a rapid, courageous, morally serious decision. She acted without hesitation. Deborah's song celebrates her: "Most blessed of women is Jael… most blessed of women in the tent" (Judges 5:24). The phrase "blessed of women" echoes through Scripture to Elizabeth's greeting to Mary ("blessed are you among women") and back to the woman of Proverbs 31 whose "children rise up and call her blessed" (v. 28).

Jael embodies "she arms her loins with strength" (v. 17) in its most stark expression. She is a reminder that the poem's heroism is not soft.

Key verses: Judges 4:17–22; 5:24–27

Poem connections: vv. 17, 25, 28

Abigail — Wisdom in a Crisis

Abigail (1 Samuel 25) is one of the most remarkable figures in the Old Testament—a woman of extraordinary wisdom, courage, and speed of thought, married to a man described as "harsh and badly behaved" (1 Sam 25:3). The text introduces her as "discerning and beautiful."

When her husband Nabal insulted David and his men, setting the household on a path toward massacre, it was Abigail who acted. Without telling Nabal, she loaded donkeys with food, rode out to meet David, dismounted before him, and delivered one of the most theologically sophisticated speeches in the entire narrative books. She addressed David's anger, appealed to his future kingship, invoked the LORD's protection, asked for forgiveness on behalf of her household, and—in a remarkable closing move—predicted David's eventual kingship (1 Sam 25:24–31). Her instruction saved a future king from the guilt of unnecessary bloodshed.

David's response is immediate: "Blessed be your discernment, and blessed be you" (1 Sam 25:33). He receives her counsel. He changes course. He changes his mind because of a woman's wisdom. After Nabal's death, David sought her as a wife—recognising that this was the kind of woman whose counsel he wanted beside him.

Key verses: 1 Samuel 25:3, 14–31, 39–42

Poem connections: vv. 11, 23, 25, 26

Esther — Dignity in the Face of Death

Esther's story is one of the greatest narratives of courage in all of Scripture, made more remarkable by its hiddenness. God is never explicitly mentioned in the book of Esther. Yet his hand is everywhere—and so is a woman who had quietly formed the kind of character that was ready when everything depended on it.

Esther did not act impulsively. When Mordecai urged her to intercede for her people, she first called for three days of fasting—for herself, her maids, all the Jews of Susa (Esther 4:16). She prepared. She took counsel. She considered the field before she bought it (cf. v. 16). Then she acted: "I will go to the king, which is against the law; and if I perish, I perish" (Esther 4:16). She said it twice because she knew it might happen. And still she went.

"Strength and dignity are her clothing; she laughs at the time to come" (v. 25). Esther's laughter is not naive—it is the laughter of a woman who has given her outcome to God and is therefore free to act without being paralysed by fear. Her royal robes in chapter 5 are beautiful, but her real clothing was the dignity she wore before she put them on.

The book ends with Esther's decrees recorded throughout the empire (Esther 9:29–32)—her works praising her "in the gates" (v. 31) at the highest possible level.

Key verses: Esther 4:12–16; 5:1–3; 9:29–32

Poem connections: vv. 16, 21, 22, 25, 28, 30, 31

Hannah — Prayer as the Foundation of Provision

Hannah (1 Samuel 1–2) is the great exemplar of prayer in the Old Testament—and her story is one of the most poignant and ultimately triumphant in all of Scripture. Barren and despised by her rival Peninnah, Hannah brought her grief to the LORD with such intensity that Eli the priest thought she was drunk. Her lips moved but no sound came—she was praying with her whole body, her whole heart. She vowed. She waited. She was faithful.

What elevates Hannah beyond the typical "answered prayer" story is her response. She had prayed for a son. She received him. And then she gave him back—taking Samuel to Eli at Shiloh and dedicating him to the LORD's service for life (1 Sam 1:27–28). Her generosity outran even what God had asked of her.

Her song in 1 Samuel 2:1–10—the Magnificat's direct precursor—is a theological declaration of the LORD's character: he lifts the poor from the dust, he exalts the humble, he brings down the mighty. Mary of Nazareth almost certainly knew it by heart. Hannah's song shaped the understanding of what God's kingdom looks like centuries before Jesus arrived.

Key verses: 1 Samuel 1:10–18, 26–28; 2:1–10

Poem connections: vv. 15, 20, 28, 30

Lydia — The Businesswoman of Purple

Lydia (Acts 16:14–15, 40) is introduced with unusual precision: she is "a seller of purple goods, from the city of Thyatira, who was a worshipper of God." Luke gives us her profession, her city of origin, and her spiritual status in one sentence. She is a woman of means, commerce, and faith—and the combination is presented as entirely unremarkable. It is simply who she is.

Purple dye in the ancient world was extraordinarily expensive—made from the murex sea snail and worth more than its weight in gold. Lydia's trade was not a small-scale craft. She was dealing in luxury goods across significant geographic distances. She was, in the terms of Proverbs 31, making fine garments and selling them, delivering to the merchant (v. 24)—except her "cloth" was purple, and her merchant connections were empire-wide. Note the direct echo: the Woman of Valour's clothing is "fine linen and purple" (v. 22)—the very material Lydia traded.

She was gathered with women at a place of prayer by the river when Paul arrived. The LORD opened her heart (16:14). She and her entire household were baptised. And then, immediately, she acted: "If you have judged me to be faithful to the Lord, come into my house and stay." She "prevailed upon" them (16:15)—the verb suggests insistence, not polite invitation. Lydia becomes the founding patron of the church at Philippi, the church Paul wrote to in his most affectionate letter. Her works praise her in the gates of every church that has ever read Philippians.

Key verses: Acts 16:13–15, 40; Philippians 1:3–5

Poem connections: vv. 13, 14, 16, 22, 24, 25, 27, 30, 31

Priscilla — The Teacher of Apollos

Priscilla (also called Prisca) is mentioned six times in the New Testament, and in four of those six mentions she is named before her husband Aquila—a highly unusual inversion for the cultural context, almost certainly indicating that she was the more prominent of the two in the Christian community.

She and Aquila were tentmakers—a skilled trade requiring technical knowledge and business acumen (Acts 18:2–3). They hosted a church in their home in Corinth, then Rome, then Ephesus (Romans 16:5; 1 Corinthians 16:19). Their home was a centre of the early Christian mission. She was not merely present; she was central.

The key moment comes in Acts 18:24–26. Apollos—described as “an eloquent man, competent in the Scriptures”—arrived in Ephesus and began teaching in the synagogue. Priscilla and Aquila heard him and recognised a gap in his understanding. They “took him aside and explained to him the way of God more accurately.” Priscilla taught a gifted male preacher. She did so with grace, precision, and evident knowledge. She opens her mouth with wisdom; kind instruction is on her tongue (v. 26). Apollos went on to become one of the most effective preachers of the early church.

Paul calls her a “fellow worker in Christ Jesus” who “risked their necks” for his life (Romans 16:3–4). She is a woman of chayil—strength, risk, and wisdom in service of the kingdom.

Key verses: Acts 18:2–3, 18–19, 24–26; Romans 16:3–5; 1 Corinthians 16:19

Poem connections: vv. 11, 13, 16, 24, 25, 26, 27, 31

Mary of Bethany — The Good Portion

Mary of Bethany appears three times in the Gospels, and each time she is at the feet of Jesus: listening to him teach (Luke 10:39), mourning after Lazarus’s death (John 11:32), and anointing his feet with expensive perfume (John 12:3). Her posture is constant: she is always oriented toward Jesus.

This is, at first, a striking contrast to the industrious energy of Proverbs 31. The Woman of Valour does so much. Mary appears to do only one thing. But Jesus’s response to Martha reveals the deeper point: “Mary has chosen the good portion, which will not be taken away from her” (Luke 10:42). The Greek verb is eklegomai—to choose deliberately from among alternatives. Mary has not drifted into passive sitting. She has actively chosen to prioritise one thing. And that one thing—the fear of the LORD, sitting at his feet, hearing his word—is, per Proverbs 31:30, the root of everything the poem describes.

The anointing in John 12 adds a further dimension. Mary took a pound of pure nard (worth about a year’s wages) and anointed Jesus’s feet. Judas protested: this could have been given to the poor. But Jesus defended her: “She has done this in preparation for my burial” (John 12:7). Mary had understood something the disciples had not yet grasped. She “extended her hands to the needy” (v. 20) in the most extravagant possible way: to the One who would bear the world’s need on a cross.

Key verses: Luke 10:38–42; John 11:28–32; John 12:1–8

Poem connections: vv. 20, 26, 28, 30

Mary Magdalene — First Witness of the Resurrection

Mary Magdalene is perhaps the most misrepresented woman in Christian history—wrongly identified with the unnamed sinful woman of Luke 7, and traditionally depicted as a reformed prostitute with no biblical basis. What the Bible actually says is simpler and more remarkable: she was a woman from whom Jesus had cast out seven demons (Luke 8:2), who became one of his most devoted followers, and who was the first human being to witness the risen Christ.

She was at the cross when nearly all of the male disciples had fled (Mark 15:40–41). She was at the burial (Matthew 27:61). She arrived at the empty tomb “while it was still dark” (John 20:1)—she rises while it is yet night (v. 15), her lamp not gone out (v. 18). And she was the first person the risen Jesus chose to appear to—commissioning her as the first herald of the resurrection (John 20:17–18).

The early church called her Apostola Apostolorum—Apostle to the Apostles. The one who proclaimed the resurrection to those who would proclaim it to the world. Her testimony, given in that upper room, was the seed of everything that followed. Let her works praise her in the gates (v. 31)—and they have, in every Easter proclamation since.

Key verses: Luke 8:1–3; Mark 15:40–41; John 20:1–18

Poem connections: vv. 15, 18, 28, 30, 31

Dorcas / Tabitha — Her Works Were Her Testimony

Dorcas (Acts 9:36–42) appears in only eleven verses, but her impact was immediate and community-wide. She was a disciple—Luke uses the feminine form of the Greek mathētria—who was "always doing good and helping the poor." When she died, the widows of Joppa stood around Peter weeping and showing him the tunics and garments she had made (Acts 9:39).

She had worked with her hands (v. 13). She had extended her hands to the needy (v. 20). She had clothed the vulnerable—and her work was so personal, so tangible, that the widows were not simply grieving a benefactor. They were grieving a friend who had made their clothes.

Peter raised her from the dead. The text gives us the moment with great simplicity: "He called the saints and widows and presented her alive" (Acts 9:41). Her resurrection became a turning point for the whole region: "it became known throughout all Joppa, and many believed in the Lord" (Acts 9:42). Her works praised her in the gates—literally, through the gates of death and back.

Key verses: Acts 9:36–42

Poem connections: vv. 13, 19, 20, 24, 28, 31

The Daughters of Zelophehad — Claiming Their Inheritance

The five daughters of Zelophehad—Mahlah, Noah, Hoglah, Milcah, and Tirzah (Numbers 27)—appear in one of the most quietly revolutionary moments in the Pentateuch. Their father had died without male heirs. Under existing law, his property would pass to the nearest male relative, leaving his daughters with nothing.

They went to Moses. To the priest Eleazar. To the leaders. To the whole congregation. At the entrance to the tent of meeting (Numbers 27:2). They stated their case clearly, without apology, without hysteria: "Why should the name of our father be removed from his family, because he had no son? Give to us a possession among our father's brothers" (Numbers 27:4).

God's response to Moses is remarkable: "The daughters of Zelophehad are right… You shall give them possession of an inheritance among their father's brothers" (Numbers 27:7). God changed the law. Five women changed Israelite inheritance law. They "considered a field, and bought it" (v. 16)—not metaphorically but legally and nationally, on behalf of their father's memory and every daughter who would come after them. Their case is settled definitively in Joshua 17 when they successfully claim their land in Canaan.

Key verses: Numbers 27:1–8; Joshua 17:3–6

Poem connections: vv. 16, 25, 26, 31

Anna the Prophetess — The Long Vigil

Anna (Luke 2:36–38) is one of the most quietly magnificent figures in the New Testament. She was "a prophetess, the daughter of Phanuel, of the tribe of Asher." She had been married seven years before her husband died, and had then lived as a widow until she was eighty-four—decades of faithful obscurity. During those years, "she did not depart from the temple, worshipping with fasting and prayer night and day." Her whole life was a single extended act of worship.

Her lamp does not go out by night (v. 18) in the most literal and sustained sense in all of Scripture. She is the keeper of the long vigil.

When Mary and Joseph brought the infant Jesus to the temple, Anna "came up at that very hour and began to give thanks to God and to speak of him to all who were waiting for the

redemption of Jerusalem" (Luke 2:38). She had waited for decades. She recognised him in an instant. She immediately became a witness—opening her mouth in public to speak of what she had seen, to all who had ears to hear. She opens her mouth with wisdom (v. 26).

Key verses: Luke 2:36–38

Poem connections: vv. 15, 18, 26, 30, 31

Eunice and Lois — Mothers of Faith

Eunice and Lois appear only briefly in the New Testament, but their influence spans generations. Paul writes to Timothy: "I am reminded of your sincere faith, a faith that dwelt first in your grandmother Lois and your mother Eunice and now, I am sure, dwells in you as well" (2 Timothy 1:5). Faith as inheritance. Faith as something transmitted and nurtured in the ordinary daily life of a family.

Eunice was a Jewish believer married to a Greek man (Acts 16:1)—which means she navigated a cross-cultural marriage in a world where that was unusual, apparently without losing either her faith or her son. Timothy knew "the sacred writings" from childhood (2 Timothy 3:15)—which means Eunice and Lois had taught him the Scriptures from infancy. Kind instruction had been on their tongues (v. 26). The fruit of that instruction became one of the most significant young leaders of the early church—a man discipled by Paul himself.

Their children rose up and called them blessed (v. 28)—not in words, but in a life. Timothy is their testimony.

Key verses: Acts 16:1; 2 Timothy 1:5; 3:14–15

Poem connections: vv. 26, 27, 28, 30

Phoebe — The Deaconess Who Carried Romans

Phoebe receives one of the most compressed but significant introductions in the New Testament. Paul writes in Romans 16:1–2: "I commend to you our sister Phoebe, a deaconess of the church at Cenchreae, that you may welcome her in the Lord in a way worthy of the saints, and help her in whatever she may need from you, for she has been a patron of many and of myself as well."

She was a diakonos—a deacon or minister—of the church at Cenchreae, the eastern port of Corinth. She was a prostatis—a patron or benefactor—of many, including Paul himself. Patrons in the Roman world were people of social standing and financial means who used their resources to support others. Phoebe was that person for the apostle.

Most significantly: the scholarly consensus is that Phoebe was the courier who carried Paul's letter to the Romans from Corinth to Rome—which means she carried what is arguably the most theologically dense letter ever written across the Mediterranean, and as the letter's bearer, she would have been the one to read it aloud to the Roman church and field questions about its content. She was, in effect, the letter's first expositor. She delivered sashes to the merchant (v. 24)—in the highest possible sense. She delivered the most important document in the history of Christian theology. Let her works praise her in the gates (v. 31).

Key verses: Romans 16:1–2

Poem connections: vv. 13, 16, 20, 24, 25, 31

The Shunammite Woman — Practical Hospitality and Resilient Faith

The unnamed Shunammite woman (2 Kings 4 and 8) is one of the Old Testament's most three-dimensional characters. She was "a wealthy woman" who "urged" Elisha to eat with her (4:8)—the same verb used of Lydia's compelling hospitality in Acts 16:15. She then took the practical initiative of persuading her husband to build a small room on the roof for Elisha—furnishing it with a bed, a table, a chair, and a lamp (4:10). Her practical generosity was precise

and thoughtful: she looked well to the ways of her household (v. 27) with careful, anticipatory wisdom.

When her son died suddenly, she did not panic. She laid him on Elisha's bed, saddled a donkey, and rode urgently to Elisha—saying to her husband: "All is well" (2 Kings 4:23) and then to Elisha's servant: "All is well" (4:26). Only when she reached Elisha himself did she fall at his feet in grief. She managed her household and her emotions with remarkable steadiness. "Strength and dignity are her clothing; she laughs at the time to come" (v. 25).

She reappears in 2 Kings 8—seven years after leaving the land during a famine—calmly petitioning the king for the restoration of her house and land. And she received it. She considers a field, and she gets it back.

Key verses: 2 Kings 4:8–37; 8:1–6

Poem connections: vv. 11, 16, 20, 21, 25, 27

Rahab — Fear of the LORD as the Root of Courage

Rahab (Joshua 2; 6:22–25; Matthew 1:5; Hebrews 11:31; James 2:25) is one of the most surprising entries in the hall of faith—a Canaanite woman from Jericho who hid the Israelite spies and secured her family's survival. She is cited in two New Testament passages as a model of saving faith.

What drove her? She tells the spies directly: "I know that the LORD has given you the land… for the LORD your God, he is God in the heavens above and on the earth beneath" (Joshua 2:9, 11). Her fear of the LORD (v. 30) was the root of her courage, her hospitality, her willingness to risk her own life for strangers. She secured her family's safety through the scarlet cord (Joshua 2:18)—a detail that has resonated as a foreshadowing of redemption.

She joined the people of Israel (Joshua 6:25). She married into the tribe of Judah. Her son was Boaz—the man who would call Ruth an eshet chayil. Her name appears in Matthew 1:5 in the genealogy of Jesus. From Jericho to Bethlehem to Nazareth: Rahab's fear of the LORD sent ripples into the history of salvation that reached the manger.

Key verses: Joshua 2:1–21; 6:22–25; Hebrews 11:31; James 2:25; Matthew 1:5

Poem connections: vv. 20, 21, 25, 30, 31

The Widow with Two Mites — Extravagant Generosity

The unnamed widow of Mark 12:41–44 is perhaps the most radical exemplar of Proverbs 31:20 in the Gospels. Jesus sat opposite the temple treasury and watched. Many rich people put in large sums. The widow "put in two small copper coins, which make a penny."

Jesus called his disciples over: "This poor widow has put in more than all those who are contributing to the offering box. For they all contributed out of their abundance, but she out of her poverty has put in everything she had, all she had to live on" (Mark 12:43–44). She gave 100%. She extended her hands to the needy (v. 20) with nothing held back. She did not eat the bread of idleness (v. 27)—though she had practically nothing to eat. Her trust in God was total.

She is anonymous. But her works are praised in the gates of history by Jesus himself—and by every sermon that has ever been preached on her. She is the poem's most radical illustration of "giving of the fruit of her hands" (v. 31).

Key verses: Mark 12:41–44; Luke 21:1–4

Poem connections: vv. 20, 27, 30, 31

Mary, Mother of Jesus — Favoured and Faithful

Mary of Nazareth sits at the centre of the New Testament's gallery of women. She was chosen, not for her accomplishments, but for her character. The angel calls her kecharitomēne—"highly favoured" or "graced" (Luke 1:28). Her response to the most disruptive news any human being has ever received was measured, theologically curious, and ultimately surrendered: "Behold, I am the servant of the Lord; let it be to me according to your word" (Luke 1:38). She laughed at the future—not because she didn't understand the cost, but because she trusted the One who had spoken.

Her Magnificat (Luke 1:46–55) is the most theologically dense poem a woman speaks in the New Testament—a meditation on the character of God, the reversal of social orders, the faithfulness of the covenant. It draws directly on Hannah's song and the language of the Psalms. She opens her mouth with wisdom (v. 26). She treasured words and pondered them in her heart (Luke 2:19, 51)—she does not eat the bread of idleness (v. 27) but the bread of contemplation, which feeds everything else.

She was at the cross (John 19:25). She was in the upper room at Pentecost (Acts 1:14). She stayed through everything. And her own prophecy has been continuously fulfilled: "henceforth all generations will call me blessed" (Luke 1:48)—her children rising up, generation after generation, to call her blessed (v. 28).

Key verses: Luke 1:26–55; John 2:1–5; 19:25–27; Acts 1:14

Poem connections: vv. 11, 25, 26, 28, 30

13. Scholarly Resources

The following resources combine rigorous scholarship with accessibility for pastoral and devotional use. Where two resources address the same question, the first listed is the more technical; the second the more accessible.

Primary Commentaries on Proverbs

- **Bruce Waltke,** *Proverbs (NICOT, 2 vols., Eerdmans, 2004–2005).* The definitive evangelical commentary. Waltke's treatment of Proverbs 31 is magisterial, with close attention to the Hebrew, the acrostic structure, and the intertextual connections to wisdom literature.
- **Tremper Longman III,** *Proverbs (Baker Commentary on the OT Wisdom and Psalms, Baker, 2006).* Readable and theologically rich, excellent on the literary context and the relationship between Proverbs 31 and the wisdom poetry of Proverbs 1–9.
- **Roland Murphy,** *Proverbs (Word Biblical Commentary, Nelson, 1998).* More technical; particularly valuable on the history of interpretation and the ancient Near Eastern parallels.
- **Ellen F. Davis,** *Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, and the Song of Songs (Westminster Bible Companion, WJK, 2000).* Beautifully written; brings literary sensibility and theological depth together without sacrificing scholarly rigour. Particularly strong on the Woman of Valour as embodied wisdom.

Women's Scholarship and Feminist Readings

- **Christine Roy Yoder,** *Wisdom as a Woman of Substance (de Gruyter, 2001).* Groundbreaking study of the economic and social dimensions of the Woman of Valour. Argues that the poem's commercial language is intentional, sophisticated, and deserves to be taken seriously—not domesticated.
- **Carolyn Custis James,** *The Gospel of Ruth: Loving God Enough to Break the Rules (Zondervan, 2008).* Superb on the Ruth–Proverbs 31 intertextual connection and the meaning of chayil. Essential reading for anyone working with this poem in a women's context.
- **Phyllis Trible,** *God and the Rhetoric of Sexuality (Fortress, 1978).* A landmark feminist literary reading. Valuable for the close reading of women's texts in the OT, even for readers who do not share all of Trible's conclusions.

For Women's Devotional Groups

- **Kathleen Nielson,** *Proverbs: The Ways of Wisdom (P&R, 2018).* An excellent women's Bible study with strong exegetical foundations. Accessible without being shallow.
- **Lois Tverberg,** *Walking in the Dust of Rabbi Jesus (Zondervan, 2012).* Invaluable for understanding the Jewish cultural and liturgical context of Proverbs 31, including the Shabbat tradition of Eshet Chayil.

On the Book of Ruth

- **Robert Hubbard,** *The Book of Ruth (NICOT, Eerdmans, 1988).* Standard commentary; excellent on the chayil connection between Ruth and Proverbs 31, and on the legal and cultural dimensions of the redemption narrative.

- **Daniel I. Block,** *Judges, Ruth (NAC, Broadman & Holman, 1999).* Thorough evangelical treatment with careful attention to the Hebrew and the narrative theology.

On Women in the New Testament

- **Lynn Cohick,** *Women in the World of the Earliest Christians (Baker, 2009).* The most comprehensive scholarly treatment of the social, economic, and religious world of NT women. Essential background for Lydia, Priscilla, Phoebe, and Dorcas.
- **N. T. Wright,** *Paul and the Faithfulness of God (Fortress, 2013), ch. 16.* Wright's treatment of women in the Pauline communities is theologically nuanced and culturally informed.